Wanda's Visit

By Christopher Durang

This is the home of JIM and MARSHA. They enter and come to speak to the audience. They are attractive, in their mid- to late thirties. Their manner in talking to the audience is that of telling a story, but also, perhaps, of explaining themselves to a marriage counselor.

JIM: Our lives had been seeming dull for a while. You know, nothing major, just sometimes being quiet at dinner. And then the next week I got this letter from this old classmate of mine.

MARSHA: Wanda. He'd never mentioned her.

JIM: Well, she was just some girlfriend. You know. High school.

MARSHA: Wanda.

JIM: And Wanda wrote me, saying she'd like to visit. And I asked Marsha if she'd mind.

MARSHA: I have trouble saying no, most women do, I think. It's not pleasing or something.

JIM: And I asked you if you'd mind, and you said, it would be fine. I thought it would be fun. You know, to mull over the old high school days . . . So I wrote Wanda back, and told her we'd love to have her visit. In high school Wanda had been quite a looker.

MARSHA: To meet an old high school fantasy. Lucky me.

JIM: And so we waited for her visit.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

Wanda's Visit by Christopher Durang

(Offstage we hear great whooping and enthusiastic cries of "Jim! Jim!" WANDA is also late thirties, early forties, but unlike JIM and MARSHA, she is not in as good shape. Her clothes are a little gaudy, her hair looks odd or messy, and she carries a sense of emotional disarray with her. But she also looks kind of fun and colorful.)

WANDA: *(With longing.)* Jim!!! *(WANDA throws her arms around JIM with great abandon, and then holds this embrace as if her life depended on it. MARSHA goes closer to them and waits patiently for the appropriate moment to be introduced.) (Still embracing him.)* Jim. Jim. Oh, Jim, Jim.

MARSHA: *(Since the embrace doesn't seem to be ending.)* Hello. I'm Marsha, Jim's wife.

WANDA: *(Breaking from the embrace.)* Oh, hello. Nice to see you. I was just so excited at seeing this guy. Hey, guy. Hey. How ya doin'?

JIM: I'm fine. *(A little uncertain he recognizes her.)* Wanda? -- didn't you used to be blond?

WANDA: Yeah, and I didn't used to be fat either-although I'm not really fat, my woman's group doesn't let me say that, I just have a food problem and some of it shows. But really I just lost twenty pounds. You should have seen me last month. Oh, give me another hug, guy. *(WANDA gives JIM another bear hug.)* Hrrrrrrrrrrrrr. *(To MARSHA; with sudden focus.)* Do you have anything to eat? Pretzels or something?

MARSHA: Would you like some pate?

WANDA: Pate? *(To JIM.)* Where'd you get her, honey, the back of *The New Yorker*? *(To MARSHA.)* Sure, honey, I can eat pate as long as you have crackers with it. And maybe some pretzels.

MARSHA: Fine. I'll be right back. *(Exits to kitchen area.)*

WANDA: Oh, Jimbo, she's a jewel. An absolute jewel.

JIM: You know, I hate to say this, but I don't recognize your face actually.

WANDA: That's very perceptive, Jim. I've had plastic surgery. But it wasn't the fancy-schmancy kind to make your face look better, it was so they

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

couldn't find me. *(WANDA squeezes his *arm*. MARSHA comes in with the pate, and notices the *arm*-squeezing.)*

MARSHA: Here is the pate. Would you like a drink? *(WANDA pauses for a moment, and then begins to sob, very genuinely.) (At a loss what to say.)* Don't feel you have to have a drink.

JIM: Wanda, what's the matter?

WANDA: *(Through sobs.)* Oh, I don't want to burden you. Or your wife.

MARSHA: That's all right, I'm sure we'd love to be burdened. I mean, if it would help you.

WANDA: *(WANDA pulls herself together, and tries to explain why she felt so upset.)* Well it all started the summer after high school graduation. *(To MARSHA.)* Jim and I had gone to the prom together, and though of course nothing had been said, everyone just kind of presumed he and I would get married. My mother, my father, me, everyone. We were inseparable. From about February of senior year to June senior year, we spent every spare moment together. You gave me your class ring. Look, I have it right here. *(Looks through her purse.)* Uh-huh. Now, where is it? *(WANDA dumps out the messy contents of her purse; looks through the mess.)* No. No. Here's the prescription for Seconal I always carry with me in case I feel suicidal.

MARSHA: I don't think any of the pharmacies are open this late. *(WANDA stares at MARSHA for a moment, like a child who's crying and has suddenly been distracted.)*

JIM: Forget about the ring, Wanda. Tell us why you cried a few minutes ago.

WANDA: Isn't it obvious? Seeing the path not taken. I could have had a happy life if I married you. So anyway, you and I went to different colleges, and *then* when you didn't write me, I was heartbroken.

JIM: Wanda, if you felt this way, why didn't you tell me at the time? You

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

haven't said anything in twenty years.

WANDA: Well, I've been very busy, *(Chomps on a cracker.)* So then I went to Ann Arbor, and oh, Jim and Marsha, I'm so ashamed to tell you this-I was promiscuous.

MARSHA: Really?

WANDA: It was awful. I became a campus joke. SO anyway, the campus minister once had to give a whole sermon against me, which made me feel just awful. *(To JIM.)* And all because I was pining for you. *(weeps copiously.) (JIM and MARSHA stare at her for a little while.)* And then my second husband gave me herpes, and every time the first one would call to threaten my life, it would trigger an outbreak . . .

MARSHA: Doesn't anyone want dinner yet?

WANDA: *(Suddenly switching moods.)* Marsha sounds hungry. Sure, honey, let's go eat. *(WANDA bounds up and moves to the dining room table.)* Oh, the dinner looks beautiful. Now where was I? Uh-huh. So then there was that guy from prison. And then there was his father, Fred. Did I tell you about Fred? Well, Fred said to me, I married you because I thought you would be my anchor in the port of life, but now I think you're stark raving mad . . .

MARSHA: Could I have the salt, please? *(JIM passes MARSHA the salt.)*

WANDA: *(Continues on with story.)* So one day the washing machine blew up, and Fred said to me, you did that, everything about you is chaos, I'm leaving and I'm taking Tranquility with me.

JIM: He actually said "tranquility"?

MARSHA: *(Muttered.)* Don't ask her questions.

WANDA: *(Explaining.)* Tranquility was our dog. And I said, I'm the one who fed Tranquility, and walked her and took care of her worms, and she used to throw up on the rug, and, of course, you can't just leave it there ...

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MARSHA: Excuse me, I'll be right back.

WANDA: I hope my talking about vomit didn't make you feel sick.

MARSHA: *(Nearly out if the room.)* No, it's fine. *(MARSHA holds her head in pain. She just couldn't stand to be at the table for a minute longer)*

JIM: I think she had a hard day.

WANDA: What did she do? Spend it making up the guest room for me? Really, I can sleep anywhere. I think I'm being evicted tomorrow anyway, so I'd prefer not to be there.

JIM: That's too bad. . . . Uh-huh. Hold on to the thought. I'll be right back. *(JIM exits and finds MARSHA still clutching her head.)* Why are you hiding in the bathroom?

MARSHA: I needed aspirin. When is she leaving?

JIM: I think she's staying overnight.

MARSHA: Did she say that or did you say that? *(WANDA, bored alone, bounds into the bathroom area with them.)*

WANDA: What are you two talking about? When you live with someone, you don't have any secrets. I remember David said to me, why didn't you tell me you had herpes, and I said, I forgot, okay? People forget things, all right? And he said, not all right, I'm going to have this for life, and I said so what, you have your nose for life, is that *my* fault?

MARSHA: *(Tired, but sort annoyed of by the logic.)* Yes, but his nose wasn't your fault. .

WANDA: What? SO then I thought I'd stay out of relationships for a while, and I went to work for this lawyer, only he wasn't a regular lawyer, he was a kingpin of crime, only I didn't realize it. Eventually, of course, I had to get my face redone so they couldn't find me.

MARSHA: *(Trying to tell her no.)* Jim says you were expecting to stay overnight ...

WANDA: Thank you, I'd love to! I feel I'm just starting to scratch the surface

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

with old Jimbo here. *(A little girl.)* I hope there's a quilt. I love quilts.

MARSHA: I'll look for one. *(WANDA stares at her, happy, but doesn't get out of the way.)* You have to move or I can't get out of the bathroom.

WANDA: *(Serious.)* I'm holding you hostage.

MARSHA: What?

WANDA: *(Shifting, cheerful.)* Isn't it awful the way they take hostages now? *(Cheerfully leaves the bathroom, talking away.)* Reminds me of my life with Augie. He was really violent, but he was really little, so I was able to push him down the stairs. *(JIM and MARSHA look at one another, a little alarmed by the "hostage" exchange.*

****

WANDA: *(Happy.)* Oh, you guys, it's been a great evening. I can't believe we played games for four hours! I'm sorry I broke the lamp. Well, good night, you two. See you in the morning.

MARSHA: Good night. *(WANDA exits to the guest room. JIM and MARSHA go to their bedroom. They're too tired to talk. They kiss each other briefly and close their eyes to sleep. WANDA enters, wrapped up in a quilt.)*

WANDA: Oh, is this your bedroom? Oh, it's so pretty. *(JIM and MARSHA open their eyes, very startled.)*

MARSHA: Is something wrong with your room?

WANDA: No, it's lovely. Although not as nice as here. It makes me never want to leave. *(WANDA pulls up a chair right next to their bed. Keeps wrapped in her quilt.)*

MARSHA: Wanda, I'm sorry. I really think I need to sleep.

WANDA: You can sleep, I won't be offended. *(Clock ticks. Time passes. JIM and MARSHA change positions in bed.) (Coquettish.)* And I said, "Billy, why didn't you tell me you were sixteen?" *(Clock ticks.) (Chatty voice, just telling the*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

facts.) Teary voice, telling a tragic turning point.) And Leonard said, Wanda, you are a worthless piece of trash. And I said, don't you think I know that? Do you think this is news? *{Clock ticks.) (Energized, telling a fascinating story.)* And Howard said he wanted me to kill his mother, and I said, "Are you crazy? I've never even met your mother." And he said, "All right, I'll introduce you. *(JIM and MARSHA have closed their eyes, either asleep or pretending to be. WANDA looks over at them, suspicious.)* Are you asleep? Jim? Marsha? *(WANDA looks to see if they're asleep. She shakes their shoulders a bit, to see if she can wake them.)* Jim? Marsha? You're not pretending to be asleep, are you? *(WANDA opens MARSHA's eyelid with her finger.)* I was just checking if you were asleep. Good night. *(WANDA takes her comforter and curls up at the bottom if their bed. Then she pulls their blanket off them and onto her.)*

****

JIM and MARSHA wake up, and abruptly leave the bedroom for the dining room area.)

MARSHA: Oh God, why did she sleep on our bed? She seemed like some insane nightmare Golden Retriever. Was she always this way?

JIM: Well, she was always vivacious.

MARSHA: I see. High school prom queen. Girl Most Likely to Get Herpes.

JIM: Lots of people get herpes.

MARSHA: Yes, but they don't talk about it for three hours. Are you attracted to her?

JIM: Now come on, Marsha, she's an emotional mess.

MARSHA: You're putting up with it very patiently. Why is that?

JIM: Well, that's because . . . I feel sympathy for her. She's someone I knew once who had a life, and look what's happened to her.

MARSHA: Well, fine. I understand. I think I'll make a trip to the nearest loony bin

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and find some mental patient who finds *me* attractive. Then I'll bring him home and make you suffer through a forty-eight-hour visit while he drools on the carpet.

WANDA: *(Entering from the bedroom . . . Loudly.)* Hey! I have an idea! Why don't I cook dinner for you guys tonight? Do you like octopus?

MARSHA: Thank you, Wanda, no. I thought we'd go to a restaurant tonight. The walls in this house are starting to vibrate.

****

(Lights change. JIM, MARSHA, and WANDA sit at a table in a restaurant)

WANDA: This is such a pretty restaurant. Ohhh, I think I know someone. *(Waves, calls out to imaginary table.)* Hi, there! Oh, no, I don't know them. *(Calls out again.)* Never mind! I thought you were my gynecologist. You know, Jim, tomorrow we should get out the old yearbook. You know, Marsha, you wouldn't believe how dashing he was back then.

JIM: You're sure a shot for my ego.

MARSHA: I'd like to shoot your ego . . . *(Closes her eyes, puts her arms loose by her side, tries to relax her body.) (With eyes closed; chant-like.)* I am sitting by a tree, and there's a lovely breeze.

WANDA: This restaurant is so adorable. This whole town. You know what I'm thinking? I'm thinking of maybe moving up here to the country with you all, finding a little house to rent. Nothing's happening in my life right now; this might be just the change I might need.

MARSHA: So you're going to move up here, are you? Going to sweep up and stick your feet in the ground and root yourself in our "little neck of the woods," are you? . . . I don't want you moving here, is that clear? I don't want you invading my life with your endless ravings anymore, is that clear? *(WANDA keeps eating, seemingly just listening to what's being said, finding it interesting*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

rather than upsetting.) (To JIM.) Don't you realize she's insane? *(Almost on cue, WANDA starts choking JIM, MARSHA, look at her, shocked for a moment.)*

JIM: Shouldn't one of us do the Heimlich maneuver?

MARSHA: I don't want to do it, I don't like her. *(WANDA looks startled, even in the midst of her choking. She keeps choking and pointing to her throat.) (After a second.)* Oh, for God's sake. *(MARSHA gets up, She stands behind WANDA, puts her arms around WANDA's lower stomach and then rather violently and suddenly pulls her hands into WANDA's lower stomach. WANDA sits back down, exhausted)*

****

JIM: *(To audience.)* Well, all that happened a few weeks ago. But some good came out of it.

MARSHA: Yes. We had a big argument, and that was good. I said what I was feeling, and it was mostly negative, but it was good to say it.

JIM: And we're going to a marriage counselor who specializes in breaking down fear of intimacy in people who've known one another for over ten years . .

MARSHA: All told, I guess Wanda's visit helped to stir us up in a good way. Now if only we were happy.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Christopher Durang
Book: Durang/Durang: Four Short Plays by Christopher Durang
ISBN: 978-0822214601
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): June 1996

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier